

Emotional Regulation & Coping Skills — Reference Guide

Emotional Regulation & Coping Skills

A CBT- and DBT-informed reference of **58 skills** across four modules — with a practical 3-step guide for each, plus a wisdom-literature appendix.

58 skills · 4 modules · 14 stressors mapped
#emotional-regulation #cbt #dbt #coping-skills

Modules

Module	Orientation	Focus
Mindfulness	Acceptance	Be fully present; observe, describe, participate without judgment
Distress Tolerance	Acceptance	Survive crises and intense urges without making things worse
Emotion Regulation	Change	Understand, name, and change unwanted emotions
Interpersonal Effectiveness	Change	Ask for needs, set limits, resolve conflict

[!danger] Crisis resources This guide is for **educational and self-help purposes only** and is not a substitute for professional mental-health care. If you are in danger or having thoughts of suicide, contact the **988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline** (call or text **988** in the U.S., 988lifeline.org) or your local emergency number immediately. You do not have to be in immediate danger to reach out.

How to use this guide

Skills are arranged by **module**, then cross-indexed by **difficulty** and by the **situation or emotion** you’re facing — jump straight to what’s useful right now. Each skill includes a

description, the psychological mechanism behind it, and a 3-step practical guide for stressful moments. Use your editor’s search (Ctrl/⌘ + F) to find any skill instantly.

Quick start — first thing to try

If you feel...	Start with
Panic / flooding	TIPP — Temperature or Paced Breathing
Intense anger / about to act	STOP skill, then a Time-Out Request
Urge or craving	Urge Surfing or ACCEPTS Distraction
Rumination / looping thoughts	Thought Labeling or Leaves on a Stream
Sadness / withdrawal	Opposite Action or Build Positive Experiences
Shame / self-criticism	Nonjudgmental Stance or Cognitive Reframing
Overwhelm / can’t think	5-4-3-2-1 Grounding or Breath Counting
Conflict / conversation	DEAR MAN with GIVE and FAST

The four modules

DBT, developed by psychologist Marsha Linehan, organizes its skills into four modules. Mindfulness and Distress Tolerance are *acceptance-oriented* — helping you tolerate reality as it is — while Emotion Regulation and Interpersonal Effectiveness are *change-oriented*, helping you build new patterns and responses. CBT coping skills such as cognitive restructuring are mapped here under the module they best fit.

- **Mindfulness** — The foundation. Skills to be fully aware and present, observe experience without judgment, and act from a grounded ‘wise mind.’
- **Distress Tolerance** — Crisis survival. Tolerate painful moments and intense urges without making things worse, plus reality-acceptance skills.
- **Emotion Regulation** — Change emotions. Understand, name, and reduce the intensity of unwanted emotions and lower baseline vulnerability.
- **Interpersonal Effectiveness** — Relationships. Ask for what you need, set limits, resolve conflict, and protect both the relationship and your self-respect.

The skill library

Forty-plus skills across four modules — now 58 in total — each with a description, the mechanism behind it, and a 3-step guide for use in stressful moments. Skills within each module are ordered from the most accessible to the more advanced.

Module 1 — Mindfulness

Mindfulness is the core module every other skill returns to. These skills train attention — to observe, describe, and participate in the present moment without judgment — so you can respond rather than react.

M01 — Wise Mind Check-In

Mindfulness · Beginner · ~Under 1 min · Anywhere

What it is. Pause to find the ‘wise mind’ — the calm overlap of emotional reactivity and cold logic — before acting on a strong feeling.

Why it works. Cognitive integration — merging emotional and logical processing into integrated, values-aligned judgment

3-step guide

1. Place a hand on your chest, close your eyes, and take three slow breaths to settle into your body.
2. Ask: ‘What is my emotion mind telling me?’ then ‘What is my reasonable mind telling me?’ Listen for the quiet, knowing voice beneath both.
3. From that grounded place, decide the next right action — one that honors the emotion without being ruled by it.

Best for: Overwhelm, Rumination, Conflict

Time to impact: 30 seconds · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip Use as a 10-second pre-step before any other skill; it primes grounded decision-making. —

M02 — Observe-Describe-Participate

Mindfulness · Intermediate · ~1-2 min · Anywhere

What it is. The core ‘what’ skills: notice the present moment, put words to it without judgment, then fully engage with the current activity.

Why it works. Defusion and attentional control — naming experience creates distance from it and disrupts automatic reactivity

3-step guide

1. Observe: silently notice sensations, thoughts, and feelings as they pass, like watching clouds, without grabbing or pushing them away.
2. Describe: put words to what you notice — ‘a tight chest,’ ‘a thought about being judged’ — sticking only to facts, no interpretations.

3. Participate: throw yourself fully into one present-moment task (washing a dish, typing a sentence), letting self-consciousness drop away.

Best for: Overwhelm, Rumination, Panic

Time to impact: 1-2 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Observing without reacting is the engine of every mindfulness skill. —

M03 — One-Mindfully

Mindfulness · Beginner · ~1-2 min · Anywhere

What it is. Do one thing at a time, with your full attention, instead of multitasking through stress.

Why it works. Attentional narrowing and single-tasking reduce cognitive load and lower sympathetic arousal

3-step guide

1. Choose one single task and set everything else physically aside (close tabs, put the phone face-down).
2. When your mind wanders — and it will — gently note ‘wandering’ and return to the one task, without scolding yourself.
3. Continue until the task or a set timer ends; notice the relief of doing one thing fully.

Best for: Work Pressure, Overwhelm, Rumination

Time to impact: 1-5 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip Especially effective against the scattered, ‘everything at once’ feeling of work pressure. —

M04 — Nonjudgmental Stance

Mindfulness · Intermediate · ~2-5 min · Anywhere

What it is. Observe your experience and replace judgmental labels (‘this is bad, I’m weak’) with neutral, factual descriptions.

Why it works. Cognitive defusion — dropping evaluative labels reduces the secondary suffering layered on top of the original emotion

3-step guide

1. Catch a judgment in flight — notice the moment you label a feeling, person, or yourself as ‘good/bad,’ ‘right/wrong.’

2. Restate it as fact: swap 'I'm so stupid for panicking' for 'a panic response is happening right now.'
3. If judgments keep returning, label the judging itself — 'judging mind is active' — and let it pass without arguing.

Best for: Shame, Rumination, Self-Criticism

Time to impact: 2-5 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Pair with Observe-Describe for maximum defusion. —

M05 — 5-4-3-2-1 Grounding

Mindfulness · Beginner · ~1-2 min · Anywhere

What it is. Anchor in the present by naming five things you see, four you hear, three you can touch, two you smell, and one you taste.

Why it works. Sensory grounding redirects attention from internal threat signals to the present external environment, interrupting panic loops

3-step guide

1. Look around and name five things you can see, saying each aloud or silently in detail (color, shape).
2. Notice four sounds — near and far — and four textures you can feel (chair, fabric, floor underfoot).
3. Find two scents and one taste (a mint, water, even the inside of your mouth), then take one slow breath and notice you are here, now.

Best for: Panic, Overwhelm, Dissociation

Time to impact: 1-2 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip Fast, portable, and discreet — usable mid-panic in public. —

M06 — Breath Counting

Mindfulness · Beginner · ~1-2 min · Anywhere

What it is. A focused breathing practice that uses counting to anchor attention and calm the nervous system.

Why it works. Paced diaphragmatic breathing activates the parasympathetic nervous system and slows heart rate

3-step guide

1. Inhale slowly through the nose for four counts, letting your belly — not your chest — rise.
2. Exhale through the mouth for six counts; after each exhale silently count ‘one,’ up to ten, then restart at one.
3. If you lose count, simply begin again at one — losing count is part of the practice, not a failure.

Best for: Panic, Overwhelm, Work Pressure

Time to impact: 1-3 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip The longer exhale is what triggers the calming response. —

M07 — Body Scan

Mindfulness · Intermediate · ~5-10 min · Private

What it is. Move attention slowly through the body from feet to head, noticing and releasing tension area by area.

Why it works. Interoceptive awareness releases held muscle tension and reconnects mind to body, lowering overall arousal

3-step guide

1. Lie or sit comfortably and bring attention to your feet; notice temperature, pressure, or tingling without trying to change anything.
2. Move attention upward — calves, thighs, belly, chest, shoulders, jaw, scalp — pausing to notice and consciously release tension in each area.
3. Finish by sensing the whole body breathing as one unit, then gently open your eyes.

Best for: Overwhelm, Panic, Work Pressure

Time to impact: 5-10 minutes · **Setting:** Private · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Best as a daily preventive practice, not only during acute spikes. —

M08 — Thought Labeling

Mindfulness · Intermediate · ~2-5 min · Anywhere

What it is. Catch recurring thoughts and label them as mental events rather than truths, loosening their grip.

Why it works. Cognitive defusion — prefacing thoughts with ‘I’m having the thought that...’ reduces literal belief in the thought’s content

3-step guide

1. When a sticky thought repeats ('I can't handle this'), pause and notice it as a thought, not a fact.
2. Reframe it: 'I'm having the thought that I can't handle this' — then go further: 'I notice I'm having the thought that...'
3. Let the thought sit like a passing train while you return attention to what you're doing; you don't have to argue with it.

Best for: Rumination, Shame, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 2-5 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Especially powerful against the spiraling self-talk of rumination. —

M09 — Leaves on a Stream

Mindfulness · Advanced · ~5-10 min · Private

What it is. A guided imagery practice where each thought or feeling is placed on a floating leaf and watched drift downstream.

Why it works. Acceptance-based defusion — placing thoughts on a visualized stream trains the mind to let experiences pass without attachment

3-step guide

1. Close your eyes and picture a slow-moving stream with leaves floating on the surface.
2. As a thought, feeling, or sensation arises, gently place it on a leaf and watch it float away — no pushing, no clinging.
3. When the mind hooks onto a leaf (and it will), notice that, place the hooking itself on a new leaf, and return to watching.

Best for: Rumination, Grief, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 5-10 minutes · **Setting:** Private · **Level:** Advanced

[!tip] Tip Requires a quiet moment; powerful for sticky grief and looping thoughts. —

M10 — Urge Surfing

Mindfulness · Advanced · ~5-10 min · Anywhere

What it is. Ride out a craving or impulse by observing it rise, peak, and fall rather than fighting or obeying it.

Why it works. Distress tolerance through mindful observation — urges crest and fall like waves if not acted on, typically peaking within 20-30 minutes

3-step guide

1. When an urge hits, pause and locate it in the body — tightness, heat, restlessness — and commit to watching it for 10 minutes.
2. Trace the urge rising, peaking, and slowly subsiding; remind yourself ‘this is a wave, and waves always fall.’
3. If the urge returns, surf it again; each time you don’t act, you weaken the neural pathway between urge and behavior.

Best for: Urges & Cravings, Intense Anger

Time to impact: 5-15 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Advanced

[!tip] Tip Set a timer for 15 minutes; most urges lose intensity before it rings. —

M11 — Effectiveness (Do What Works)

Mindfulness · Intermediate · ~1-2 min · Anywhere

What it is. Choose the course of action that is most effective for your goals and values, rather than the one that feels justified or righteous in the moment.

Why it works. Pragmatic problem-solving — focusing on what is effective rather than what is morally ‘right’ reduces rigid, emotion-driven reactivity

3-step guide

1. Pause and ask: ‘What will actually help me reach my goal here?’ — separate from ‘What do I feel entitled to do?’
2. Consider whether acting on the urge will be effective — for the relationship, the outcome, and your self-respect.
3. Choose the effective action, even when it’s not the one that feels fair.

Best for: Work Pressure, Conflict, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 1-2 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip ‘Effective’ is not the same as ‘right’ — sometimes the effective move is to let something go. —

M12 — Loving-Kindness (Metta) Practice

Mindfulness · Intermediate · ~5-10 min · Private

What it is. Silently direct warm, caring phrases toward yourself and others, in expanding circles, to cultivate compassion and soften self-criticism.

Why it works. Compassion-focused imagery activates the mammalian affiliative/soothing system, countering self-criticism and social-threat responses

3-step guide

1. Sit quietly and silently repeat toward yourself: ‘May I be safe, may I be at ease, may I be kind to myself.’
2. Extend the same phrases to someone you care about, then a neutral person, then someone difficult.
3. End by offering the phrases to all beings, and notice any softening in your chest.

Best for: Shame, Loneliness, Self-Criticism, Sadness

Time to impact: 5-10 minutes · **Setting:** Private · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip If the phrases feel false, start with ‘May I be at peace with this exactly as it is.’ —

M13 — Savoring

Mindfulness · Beginner · ~2-5 min · Anywhere

What it is. Notice a pleasant moment, then intentionally stretch it out — letting it fully register — rather than letting it pass by.

Why it works. Deliberately prolonging attention on positive experiences counteracts the negativity bias and builds positive affect

3-step guide

1. Notice one small pleasant thing right now (warmth of a drink, a patch of light, a kind word).
2. Linger on it for 20-30 seconds, letting the sensation fully land in your body.
3. Name what you appreciate about it, and let yourself feel the good without rushing past.

Best for: Sadness, Loneliness, Rumination

Time to impact: 2-5 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip The brain is wired to notice threats; savoring is the deliberate practice of noticing good. —

M14 — Gratitude Journaling

Mindfulness · Beginner · ~5-10 min · Anywhere

What it is. Write down three specific things you’re grateful for and why, to deliberately redirect attention toward what’s good.

Why it works. Intentional gratitude practice retrains attention toward positive aspects of life, reducing depressive rumination and raising baseline mood

3-step guide

1. List three concrete, specific things from today you're genuinely glad for (not abstract 'health').
2. For each, write one sentence on why it mattered to you.
3. Re-read them slowly, letting the gratitude register before moving on.

Best for: Sadness, Rumination, Loneliness

Time to impact: 5-10 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip Specificity is what makes it work — 'the way the light hit the leaves' beats 'nature.'
—

M15 — Self-Compassion Break

Mindfulness · Intermediate · ~2-5 min · Anywhere

What it is. A three-part practice — acknowledge suffering as suffering, remember you're not alone, and offer yourself kindness — for moments of pain or self-criticism.

Why it works. Self-compassion (Kristin Neff's three components) activates the soothing/affiliative system, reducing shame-based self-attack and isolation

3-step guide

1. Name it: 'This is a moment of suffering' (or 'this hurts') — validating rather than fighting the pain.
2. Normalize it: 'Suffering is part of life; I'm not the only one who feels this.'
3. Offer kindness: place a hand on your heart and say, 'May I be kind to myself in this moment.'

Best for: Shame, Self-Criticism, Sadness, Grief

Time to impact: 2-5 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Self-compassion is a skill, not a feeling — you do the steps regardless of whether you 'feel' it. —

Module 2 — Distress Tolerance

Distress tolerance skills are for crises: moments when emotion is too high (often 8/10+) for cognitive skills to land. They help you survive the moment without making it worse, and accept

reality you cannot yet change.

D01 — STOP Skill

Distress Tolerance · Beginner · ~Under 1 min · Anywhere

What it is. Stop physically, Take a step back, Observe what's happening, then Proceed mindfully — a four-part emergency brake for reactivity.

Why it works. Response inhibition — a behavioral circuit-breaker that inserts a pause between impulse and action

3-step guide

1. STOP: freeze your body mid-action — don't speak, text, send, or reach for anything.
2. Take a step back — physically move, take a breath, and Observe what you feel, want, and what the situation actually needs.
3. Proceed mindfully: choose the next action aligned with your goals and values, not the urge of the moment.

Best for: Intense Anger, Conflict, Urges & Cravings

Time to impact: 30 seconds · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip The single most useful split-second skill against angry outbursts and impulsive sends. —

D02 — TIPP — Temperature

Distress Tolerance · Beginner · ~Under 1 min · Private

What it is. Splash cold water (50-65°F) on your face, or hold a cold pack to eyes and cheeks, to abruptly downshift an extreme emotional spike.

Why it works. Mammalian dive reflex — cold water on the face triggers the vagus nerve, rapidly slowing heart rate and interrupting extreme emotional arousal

3-step guide

1. Get cold water or an ice pack; bend forward and hold your breath briefly while applying cold to your cheeks and eye area for 15-30 seconds.
2. Notice the immediate shift in heart rate and arousal as the dive reflex engages.
3. Follow with Paced Breathing (inhale 4, exhale 6) to extend the calming effect once the spike has broken.

Best for: Panic, Intense Anger, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 30-60 seconds · **Setting:** Private · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip Use only when emotion intensity is 8/10+; avoid if you have heart conditions — use cold to hands instead. —

D03 — Paced Breathing

Distress Tolerance · Beginner · ~2-5 min · Anywhere

What it is. Breathe in through the nose and out through the mouth, making each exhale longer than the inhale to calm the body.

Why it works. Extending the exhale activates the parasympathetic nervous system, lowering heart rate and cortisol

3-step guide

1. Inhale slowly through the nose to a count of four, filling the belly first.
2. Exhale through the mouth to a count of six to eight, pursing the lips slightly to slow the breath.
3. Repeat for 2-5 minutes; if it's hard, start at 3 in / 5 out and lengthen the exhale as you settle.

Best for: Panic, Work Pressure, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 2-5 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip The 'P' of TIPP; the most discreet crisis skill usable in a meeting. —

D04 — Paired Muscle Relaxation

Distress Tolerance · Intermediate · ~5-10 min · Private

What it is. Tense each muscle group briefly, then release, moving through the body to discharge stored tension.

Why it works. Progressive muscle relaxation lowers sympathetic tone and teaches the body the contrast between tension and release

3-step guide

1. Starting with your hands, tense the muscles tightly for 5-7 seconds, then release for 10 seconds, noticing the warmth of relaxation.
2. Move up the body — arms, shoulders, face, then down to chest, belly, legs, feet — tensing and releasing each group.
3. Finish by breathing naturally and noticing the overall drop in physical tension.

Best for: Panic, Work Pressure, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 5-10 minutes · **Setting:** Private · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Effective before sleep or after a high-stress day. —

D05 — ACCEPTS Distraction

Distress Tolerance · Beginner · ~5-10 min · Anywhere

What it is. Distract briefly with Activities, Contributing, Comparisons, Emotions, Pushing away, Thoughts, or Sensations to survive an urge wave.

Why it works. Attentional deployment — engaging alternative stimuli gives the emotional system time to settle without suppressing the feeling

3-step guide

1. Pick one distraction mode: do a small Activity (tidy a drawer), Contribute (text someone a kind word), or shift Emotions (watch a funny clip).
2. Engage fully with the chosen distraction for 10-15 minutes — not to avoid the feeling forever, but to give it room to crest.
3. When the intensity drops, return and notice the emotion again; distraction buys time, it doesn't replace processing.

Best for: Sadness, Rumination, Urges & Cravings

Time to impact: 5-15 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip Distraction is a crisis-survival tool, not a permanent coping strategy. —

D06 — Self-Soothe (Five Senses)

Distress Tolerance · Intermediate · ~5-10 min · Private

What it is. Comfort yourself through each of the five senses with small, intentional, pleasurable inputs.

Why it works. Sensory regulation and self-care — soothing input to each sense lowers arousal and signals safety to the nervous system

3-step guide

1. Sight: look at something beautiful — a photo, a plant, the sky — for a full minute.
2. Sound, smell, taste: play calming music, light a scent, sip a warm drink slowly and notice each sense in turn.

3. Touch: wrap in a soft blanket or hold something warm; end by placing a hand on your heart and breathing.

Best for: Sadness, Loneliness, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 5-10 minutes · **Setting:** Private · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Especially gentle for sadness, loneliness, and emotional rawness. —

D07 — IMPROVE the Moment

Distress Tolerance · Intermediate · ~5-10 min · Private

What it is. Imagery, Meaning, Prayer/Practice, Relaxation, One thing at a time, Vacation, Encouragement — seven ways to make a hard moment tolerable.

Why it works. Meaning-making and cognitive reappraisal transform an unchangeable painful moment into one that is bearable

3-step guide

1. Choose one or two: use Imagery (picture a safe place) or find Meaning ('this is hard and also temporary').
2. Relax the body or do One thing at a time; take a mini-Vacation (a 10-minute break with a cup of tea).
3. End with Encouragement — speak to yourself as you would to a dear friend in the same pain.

Best for: Grief, Overwhelm, Sadness

Time to impact: 5-15 minutes · **Setting:** Private · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Designed for pain that can't be fixed right now, only borne. —

D08 — Pros and Cons

Distress Tolerance · Intermediate · ~2-5 min · Anywhere

What it is. Weigh the pros and cons of acting on an urge versus not acting on it, ideally before the crisis peaks.

Why it works. Deliberate cost-benefit analysis engages prefrontal cortex, countering emotion-driven impulsivity

3-step guide

1. Draw two columns: 'Acting on the urge' and 'Resisting the urge.' List the pros and cons of each honestly.
2. Focus on the long-term consequences, not just the short-term relief — what will matter in a week, a month?
3. Read the list aloud, then decide your next action based on what serves your goals and values, not the spike.

Best for: Urges & Cravings, Intense Anger, Conflict

Time to impact: 3-5 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Keep a pre-written pros/cons list for recurring urges so it's ready in the moment. —

D09 — Radical Acceptance

Distress Tolerance · Advanced · ~5-10 min · Anywhere

What it is. Accept reality exactly as it is, in your body and mind, without needing it to be different in order to cope.

Why it works. Acceptance reduces secondary suffering — fighting unchangeable reality amplifies pain, while accepting it frees energy for coping

3-step guide

1. Notice where you're fighting reality ('This shouldn't be happening') and the tension it creates in your body.
2. Repeat: 'This is what happened. I may not like it, but it is real,' accepting with your whole body, not just your words.
3. Turn the mind toward what you can do now; acceptance is not approval — it's the starting point for effective action.

Best for: Grief, Sadness, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 5-15 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Advanced

[!tip] Tip Hardest skill; meant for situations you genuinely cannot change, not for injustice you can act on. —

D10 — Crisis Survival Plan

Distress Tolerance · Advanced · ~Under 1 min · Anywhere

What it is. A written, advance plan listing your warning signs, go-to crisis skills, distractions, supports, and emergency numbers.

Why it works. Implementation intention — pre-deciding coping steps in a calm state bypasses the impaired decision-making of a crisis

3-step guide

1. In a calm moment, list your personal early-warning signs and the top three skills that work for you (e.g., TIPP, Paced Breathing).
2. Add two distraction activities, two people you can call, and professional/crisis numbers (988 in the U.S.).
3. Keep it on your phone lock screen and wallet; in crisis, you only follow the list — no decisions required.

Best for: Panic, Urges & Cravings, Intense Anger

Time to impact: Immediate (when pre-made) · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Advanced

[!tip] Tip If you have any thoughts of suicide, call or text 988 now — you don't have to be in immediate danger to reach out. —

D11 — Turning the Mind

Distress Tolerance · Intermediate · ~1-2 min · Anywhere

What it is. A companion to Radical Acceptance: each time you notice yourself fighting reality again, turn your mind back toward acceptance.

Why it works. Repeatedly choosing acceptance — turning the mind back toward reality each time it resists — builds the capacity to stop fighting the unchangeable

3-step guide

1. Notice you've slipped back into fighting reality ('This shouldn't be happening').
2. Make an inner commitment to accept reality as it is — not to like it, but to stop fighting it.
3. Expect to turn back many times; each turning is the practice, not a failure.

Best for: Grief, Sadness, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 1-2 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Acceptance isn't a one-time decision — it's a direction you return to each time the mind resists. —

D12 — Willingness vs. Willfulness

Distress Tolerance · Intermediate · ~1-2 min · Anywhere

What it is. Notice whether you're being willful (refusing reality, digging in) or willing (doing what the situation needs), and choose willingness.

Why it works. Shifting from willful refusal to willing participation reduces the suffering that comes from fighting what the situation requires

3-step guide

1. Ask: 'Am I fighting what this situation requires right now?' Notice willfulness in your body and thoughts.
2. Ask: 'What would willingness look like here — doing what's needed, fully and without resentment?'
3. Take one willing action — even small — toward what the situation actually requires.

Best for: Grief, Overwhelm, Conflict

Time to impact: 1-2 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Willingness is doing what works; willfulness is refusing to, even when it costs you. —

D13 — Half-Smile & Willing Hands

Distress Tolerance · Beginner · ~Under 1 min · Anywhere

What it is. Adopt a posture of acceptance — a half-smile and relaxed, open hands — to signal acceptance to your body and mind.

Why it works. Adopting an accepting body posture (slight smile, open palms) sends acceptance signals to the nervous system, reducing the resistance that amplifies distress

3-step guide

1. Relax your face and allow a faint half-smile — lips slightly upturned, not a grin.
2. Open your hands, palms up and relaxed in your lap or on the table.
3. Hold the posture for a minute, breathing naturally, and notice any softening of resistance.

Best for: Panic, Intense Anger, Grief

Time to impact: 30-60 seconds · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip The body leads the mind; an accepting posture makes acceptance easier to reach inwardly. —

D14 — Mindfulness of Current Thoughts

Distress Tolerance · Intermediate · ~5-10 min · Private

What it is. Step back and observe your thoughts as they arise, letting them come and go without engaging, believing, or arguing with them.

Why it works. Defusion — observing thoughts as passing mental events rather than truths reduces literal belief in their content and the distress they generate

3-step guide

1. Sit quietly and watch thoughts appear and disappear, as if watching clouds or traffic.
2. When a thought hooks you, notice the hooking — ‘I’m getting caught’ — and return to observing.
3. Let thoughts be just thoughts, neither pushing them away nor following where they lead.

Best for: Rumination, Overwhelm, Shame

Time to impact: 5-10 minutes · **Setting:** Private · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip You are the sky thoughts pass through, not the thoughts themselves. —

Module 3 — Emotion Regulation

Emotion regulation skills help you understand, name, and change emotions you want to change, and lower your biological vulnerability so spikes are less frequent and less intense.

E01 — Check the Facts

Emotion Regulation · Intermediate · ~5-10 min · Anywhere

What it is. Ask whether your emotion and its intensity fit the actual facts, then check the interpretations and assumptions fueling it.

Why it works. Cognitive restructuring — testing whether an emotion’s intensity fits the facts and examining interpretations that drive it

3-step guide

1. Name the emotion and rate its intensity (0-10); ask: what is the actual event, in purely factual terms?
2. Check your interpretations and assumptions: is there another way to see this? Am I assuming the worst?
3. Ask: does the emotion’s intensity match the facts? If not, what would a more proportionate response look like?

Best for: Work Pressure, Social Anxiety, Rumination

Time to impact: 5-10 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Core CBT skill; requires enough calm to think — pair with a grounding skill first if flooded. —

E02 — Opposite Action

Emotion Regulation · Intermediate · ~5-10 min · Anywhere

What it is. When an emotion doesn't fit the facts, do the opposite of its urge: approach what you fear, engage when sad, be visible when ashamed.

Why it works. Behavioral activation — acting opposite to an emotion's action urge (when the emotion doesn't fit the facts) weakens the emotion

3-step guide

1. Identify the emotion and its action urge (sadness → withdraw; shame → hide; fear → avoid).
2. Ask if the emotion fits the facts — if it doesn't (or the situation is changeable), plan its opposite action.
3. Do the opposite all the way — body language, tone, behavior — until the emotion begins to shift.

Best for: Sadness, Shame, Loneliness

Time to impact: 5-15 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Use only when the emotion doesn't fit the facts or when change is possible; don't opposite-act to valid fear. —

E03 — Problem Solving

Emotion Regulation · Intermediate · ~10-15 min · Private

What it is. Define the problem, brainstorm options, pick one, and act — turning a vague stressor into a solvable challenge.

Why it works. Structured problem-solving reduces helplessness and converts emotional energy into controllable next steps

3-step guide

1. Define the problem in one factual sentence; break a big stressor into smaller, solvable parts.
2. Brainstorm at least three possible solutions without judging them yet, then evaluate each for feasibility and likely outcome.
3. Choose one option and define the very next concrete step you'll take, and when — then act.

Best for: Work Pressure, Conflict, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 10-20 minutes · **Setting:** Private · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Most useful once the initial emotional spike has settled. —

E04 — PLEASE Skills

Emotion Regulation · Beginner · ~15+ min · Anywhere

What it is. Treat physical illness, balance Eating, avoid mood-Altering substances, get Sleep, and Exercise — to lower your baseline emotional vulnerability.

Why it works. Reducing biological vulnerability — treating physical illness, balanced eating, avoiding mood-altering substances, sleep, exercise lowers emotional reactivity

3-step guide

1. Scan the basics right now: have I eaten, slept, hydrated? Is pain or illness present? Am I using substances to cope?
2. Address the most neglected one first — eat a real meal, drink water, step outside for movement.
3. Build a daily floor: protect sleep, move your body, eat regularly — vulnerability drops as these stabilize.

Best for: Overwhelm, Panic, Intense Anger

Time to impact: Ongoing / 15-30 min · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip The HALT check (Hungry, Angry, Lonely, Tired) is a fast version for the moment. —

E05 — Build Positive Experiences

Emotion Regulation · Intermediate · ~15+ min · Anywhere

What it is. Plan and do one pleasant and one mastery-building activity today, and build long-term goals for a life worth living.

Why it works. Behavioral activation and reward — scheduling pleasant and mastery-building activities raises mood floor and counters anhedonia

3-step guide

1. Pick one small pleasant activity you can do today (a walk, music, a favorite food) and one that builds a sense of mastery (a task you can complete).
2. Do it fully present, without multitasking; notice any flicker of enjoyment or accomplishment.
3. Plan a longer-term positive experience this week, and take one small step toward it.

Best for: Sadness, Loneliness, Shame

Time to impact: 20-60 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Counterintuitively, mood often follows action — engage first, feel better after. —

E06 — Cope Ahead

Emotion Regulation · Intermediate · ~5-10 min · Private

What it is. Rehearse a stressful situation in detail, including how you'll cope, so you're prepared when it arrives.

Why it works. Mental rehearsal and implementation intentions — pre-rehearsing a coping plan reduces anxiety and increases follow-through in the real moment

3-step guide

1. Describe a situation you're dreading, in vivid detail — who, what, when, and how it usually goes wrong.
2. Decide which coping skills you'll use and imagine executing them successfully; see yourself handling it well.
3. Rehearse your first sentence or action; when the moment comes, lean on the rehearsed plan.

Best for: Social Anxiety, Work Pressure, Conflict

Time to impact: 5-10 minutes (prep) · **Setting:** Private · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Best done the night before or morning of a known stressor. —

E07 — Name the Emotion

Emotion Regulation · Beginner · ~1-2 min · Anywhere

What it is. Identify and precisely name the emotion you're feeling, which itself begins to regulate it.

Why it works. Affect labeling — putting words to feelings reduces amygdala activity and engages prefrontal regulation

3-step guide

1. Pause and scan your body and mind for the dominant feeling; move beyond 'bad' to a specific word (resentful, embarrassed, grief-struck).
2. Rate its intensity (0-10) and note what triggered it and what the emotion is urging you to do.

3. Say aloud or write: 'I am feeling ___ because ___' — naming it begins to give you space from it.

Best for: Overwhelm, Shame, Rumination

Time to impact: 1-3 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip A quick, universal first step that makes every other skill more effective. —

E08 — Emotion Wave Mapping

Emotion Regulation · Advanced · ~5-10 min · Private

What it is. Track an emotion as a wave — its trigger, rising, peak, and fall — to learn that all feelings crest and pass.

Why it works. Psychoeducation and temporal reframing — visualizing emotions as time-limited waves reduces fear of the feeling itself

3-step guide

1. Pick a current or recent strong emotion and map its timeline: when it started, when it peaked, and how it has already begun to fall.
2. Notice prior times this emotion crested and then passed; recall how long it typically took.
3. Remind yourself: 'This is a wave, not a permanent state; it will fall' — and notice the small signs it already is.

Best for: Grief, Sadness, Intense Anger

Time to impact: 5-10 minutes · **Setting:** Private · **Level:** Advanced

[!tip] Tip Particularly freeing for grief and the fear of being overwhelmed by feeling. —

E09 — Cognitive Reframing

Emotion Regulation · Advanced · ~5-10 min · Anywhere

What it is. Identify a distorted automatic thought, examine the evidence, and reframe it into a balanced, believable alternative.

Why it works. Cognitive restructuring (CBT) — identifying and re-evaluating distorted automatic thoughts to change the emotions they generate

3-step guide

1. Catch the hot thought ('I'm going to fail, everyone will see') and write it down; note the emotion and intensity it sparks.

2. Examine the evidence for and against it; identify the distortion (catastrophizing, mind-reading, all-or-nothing).
3. Write a balanced alternative that fits the facts and is believable — not toxic positivity — then re-rate the emotion's intensity.

Best for: Rumination, Work Pressure, Shame

Time to impact: 5-15 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Advanced

[!tip] Tip Classic CBT; requires some cognitive bandwidth — use after grounding if overwhelmed. —

E10 — Values-Based Action

Emotion Regulation · Advanced · ~5-10 min · Anywhere

What it is. Identify what matters most to you and take one small action aligned with it, even when the emotion says otherwise.

Why it works. Values clarification (ACT) — connecting behavior to core values provides meaning and direction independent of current mood

3-step guide

1. Name one or two values that matter most right now (kindness, integrity, courage, connection).
2. Ask: what is one small action I could take in the next hour that embodies this value, regardless of how I feel?
3. Take that action; let the value, not the mood, lead — and notice how it feels to act on what you stand for.

Best for: Shame, Loneliness, Grief

Time to impact: 5-15 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Advanced

[!tip] Tip Powerful when emotions are heavy but life still asks something of you. —

E11 — Mindfulness of Current Emotion

Emotion Regulation · Intermediate · ~5-10 min · Anywhere

What it is. Turn toward a strong emotion and observe it as a wave of physical sensation and energy, without trying to change, suppress, or act on it.

Why it works. Observing an emotion fully — without pushing it away or acting on it — reduces its intensity and the secondary suffering of resistance

3-step guide

1. Locate the emotion in your body — its temperature, texture, movement — and let it be exactly as it is.
2. Watch it as a wave, reminding yourself it will rise and fall; don't push it away or hold onto it.
3. If the urge to act arises, note it and return to observing the sensation itself.

Best for: Intense Anger, Sadness, Panic, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 5-10 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip The goal is not to feel less, but to stop adding the suffering of resistance on top of the feeling. —

E12 — Build Mastery

Emotion Regulation · Beginner · ~15+ min · Anywhere

What it is. Do one thing — however small — that gives you a sense of competence and accomplishment, to build self-efficacy.

Why it works. Accomplishing tasks builds self-efficacy and raises the mood floor, countering helplessness and low mood

3-step guide

1. Choose a small, doable task you can complete (finish an email, tidy a drawer, take a walk).
2. Do it to completion, and let yourself register the sense of competence.
3. Build mastery into your week — a little every day — to raise your baseline mood and confidence.

Best for: Sadness, Shame, Overwhelm, Loneliness

Time to impact: 15-30 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip Start small and achievable; the point is the experience of competence, not the size of the task. —

E13 — Accumulate Positive Emotions (Long-Term)

Emotion Regulation · Intermediate · ~15+ min · Anywhere

What it is. Identify values and life goals, then take small steps toward a life worth living — to build lasting positive emotions over time.

Why it works. Building a life with positive experiences and meaning raises the long-term mood floor and buffers against future emotional crashes

3-step guide

1. Name one value that matters to you (connection, creativity, service, learning).
2. Choose one small, concrete step toward it you could take this week.
3. Take that step; long-term positive emotion is built one value-aligned action at a time.

Best for: Sadness, Loneliness, Shame

Time to impact: 20-60 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Short-term pleasant activities lift the moment; long-term ones build a life that sustains you. —

E14 — Thought Record (CBT)

Emotion Regulation · Advanced · ~5-10 min · Anywhere

What it is. A structured CBT tool: record the situation, your emotion, the automatic thought, evidence for and against it, and a balanced reframe.

Why it works. The CBT thought record externalizes automatic thoughts, tests them against evidence, and builds balanced alternatives — restructuring the cognition driving the emotion

3-step guide

1. Note the situation and the emotion it sparked; write the hot automatic thought in one sentence.
2. List evidence that supports the thought, then evidence that contradicts it.
3. Write a balanced alternative thought that fits all the evidence, and re-rate the emotion's intensity.

Best for: Rumination, Shame, Work Pressure, Social Anxiety

Time to impact: 5-15 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Advanced

[!tip] Tip Keep a thought-record template on your phone so it's ready when the spiral starts. —

E15 — Identifying Cognitive Distortions

Emotion Regulation · Intermediate · ~2-5 min · Anywhere

What it is. Learn the common thinking traps, then catch and name the one operating in a distressing thought — the first step to loosening it.

Why it works. Naming the specific distortion (catastrophizing, all-or-nothing, mind-reading) weakens its grip by making the thinking error visible

3-step guide

1. Catch a distressing thought and write it down verbatim.
2. Match it to a distortion: all-or-nothing, catastrophizing, mind-reading, overgeneralizing, shoulds, personalizing.
3. Simply naming it — ‘that’s catastrophizing’ — begins to create distance from the thought’s content.

Best for: Rumination, Shame, Self-Criticism

Time to impact: 3-5 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Pair with Cognitive Reframing or a Thought Record to actively restructure the thought. —

E16 — Behavioral Experiments (CBT)

Emotion Regulation · Advanced · ~15+ min · Anywhere

What it is. Design a small real-world test of a fearful belief, run it, and compare the outcome to your prediction — to learn from experience, not assumption.

Why it works. CBT behavioral experiments directly test the predictions of anxious beliefs against reality, providing experiential disconfirmation that cognitive argument cannot

3-step guide

1. Write the belief and your specific prediction (‘If I speak up, I’ll be judged’) and rate your confidence (0-100%).
2. Run the experiment — actually do the feared action, and observe what happens.
3. Compare the result to your prediction; note what you learned for next time.

Best for: Social Anxiety, Shame, Rumination

Time to impact: 15-60 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Advanced

[!tip] Tip Start with low-stakes experiments and build up; the evidence from doing outweighs the evidence from thinking. —

E17 — Worry Postponement

Emotion Regulation · Intermediate · ~1-2 min · Anywhere

What it is. When a worry intrudes, note it and defer it to a set 15-minute ‘worry window’ later — containing rumination without suppressing it.

Why it works. Scheduling a fixed ‘worry time’ contains rumination rather than suppressing it, reducing intrusion outside the window

3-step guide

1. Notice the worry intruding; jot it down rather than engaging it now.
2. Tell yourself: ‘I’ll come back to this at [set time],’ and return to what you were doing.
3. At the worry window, review the list — problem-solve what you can, and let go of what you can’t.

Best for: Rumination, Work Pressure, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 1-2 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Paradoxically, giving worry a set place reduces how much it takes over the day. —

E18 — Activity Scheduling (Behavioral Activation)

Emotion Regulation · Intermediate · ~10-15 min · Anywhere

What it is. Plan specific activities — including ones you don’t feel like — across the day, and do them on schedule rather than by mood.

Why it works. Behavioral activation — scheduling mastery and pleasure activities into the day — breaks the depression-inactivity cycle where low mood leads to withdrawal and deeper low mood

3-step guide

1. List the day’s hours; schedule one mastery and one pleasure activity into specific time slots.
2. Do each at its scheduled time, regardless of motivation — action precedes feeling, not the reverse.
3. Rate your mood before and after; notice that doing often precedes wanting to.

Best for: Sadness, Overwhelm, Loneliness

Time to impact: 10-15 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip When mood is lowest, the instinct is to wait until you ‘feel like it’ — that’s the trap; schedule it anyway. —

Module 4 — Interpersonal Effectiveness

Interpersonal effectiveness skills help you ask for what you need, say no, resolve conflict, and repair ruptures — while protecting the relationship and your self-respect.

I01 — DEAR MAN

Interpersonal Effectiveness · Intermediate · ~5-10 min · Anywhere

What it is. Describe the situation factually, Express your feeling, Assert your request, Reinforce the benefit, stay Mindful, Appear confident, and Negotiate.

Why it works. Assertiveness training — a structured script for making requests or saying no while protecting the relationship and self-respect

3-step guide

1. Describe the situation in pure facts ('When deadlines shift without notice...'), then Express your feeling ('...I feel overwhelmed').
2. Assert your request clearly ('Could we agree on 48 hours' notice?') and Reinforce the benefit to them ('That way I deliver better work').
3. Stay Mindful (don't get derailed), Appear confident (eye contact, steady voice), and Negotiate if needed — offer a middle path.

Best for: Conflict, Work Pressure, Social Anxiety

Time to impact: 5-10 minutes (script) · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Script it out beforehand; the structure keeps you out of emotion-driven spirals. —

I02 — GIVE

Interpersonal Effectiveness · Intermediate · ~2-5 min · Anywhere

What it is. Keep a relationship intact during a hard conversation: be Gentle, Interested, Validate the other, and use an Easy manner.

Why it works. Relationship preservation — acting Gentle, Interested, Validating, and with an Easy manner keeps the other person receptive

3-step guide

1. Be Gentle — no attacks, sarcasm, or threats; keep your tone and body language soft.
2. Be Interested — listen fully, make eye contact; Validate the other person's feelings even if you disagree with their facts.
3. Use an Easy manner — a little lightness, not a heavy lecture; this disarms defensiveness and keeps the door open.

Best for: Conflict, Loneliness, Social Anxiety

Time to impact: In-the-moment · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Pair with DEAR MAN — GIVE for the relationship, DEAR MAN for the ask. —

I03 — FAST

Interpersonal Effectiveness · Intermediate · ~2-5 min · Anywhere

What it is. Keep your self-respect in a tough interaction: be Fair, don't over-Apologize, Stick to your values, and be Truthful.

Why it works. Self-respect preservation — staying Fair, making no Apologies for existing, Sticking to values, and being Truthful protects self-worth

3-step guide

1. Be Fair — to yourself and the other; don't take more than your share of blame.
2. Don't over-Apologize for having needs or existing; Stick to your values rather than abandoning them to please.
3. Be Truthful — don't lie or exaggerate to smooth things over; honesty preserves your self-respect long-term.

Best for: Conflict, Shame, Social Anxiety

Time to impact: In-the-moment · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip FAST counterbalances GIVE — GIVE protects the relationship, FAST protects you. —

I04 — Boundary Script

Interpersonal Effectiveness · Intermediate · ~2-5 min · Anywhere

What it is. A clear, kind script for stating a limit — what you can and can't do — without over-explaining or apologizing.

Why it works. Assertive limit-setting reduces resentment and burnout by making your limits explicit and respectful

3-step guide

1. Name the limit plainly: 'I can't take that on this week' or 'I need to leave by 5 today.'
2. Give a brief, honest reason without over-explaining or justifying; resist the urge to apologize for having limits.
3. Offer an alternative if appropriate ('I can look at it Monday') and hold the line kindly if pushed.

Best for: Conflict, Work Pressure, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 2-5 minutes (script) · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Rehearse a go-to phrase so it's ready when guilt is loud. —

105 — Broken Record

Interpersonal Effectiveness · Beginner · ~1-2 min · Anywhere

What it is. Calmly repeat your core statement, without adding fuel, when someone pressures, argues, or tries to derail you.

Why it works. Persistence without escalation — repeating a clear statement avoids being drawn into argument or emotional derailment

3-step guide

1. Decide on your one clear statement ('I won't be able to lend the money') and keep it short.
2. When pushed, repeat the same statement calmly, word for word — no new arguments, no rising volume.
3. Hold steady through 2-4 repetitions; most pressure loses steam when it fails to provoke a reaction.

Best for: Conflict, Social Anxiety, Intense Anger

Time to impact: 1-3 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip Defuses pressure without giving in or escalating into a fight. —

106 — Validation Before Request

Interpersonal Effectiveness · Intermediate · ~2-5 min · Anywhere

What it is. Acknowledge the other person's feelings and perspective before asking for anything — making them more likely to hear you.

Why it works. Reflective listening lowers the other's defensiveness, making them far more receptive to your needs

3-step guide

1. Reflect back what you hear them saying and feeling: 'It sounds like you're stressed and feel unheard right now.'
2. Validate that their feeling makes sense given their perspective — without necessarily agreeing with the facts.
3. Only then make your request; a validated person is dramatically more open to one.

Best for: Conflict, Loneliness, Social Anxiety

Time to impact: 2-5 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Validation isn't agreement — it's acknowledgment that their experience is real to them. —

I07 — Assertive I-Statements

Interpersonal Effectiveness · Beginner · ~1-2 min · Anywhere

What it is. Express your feelings and needs using 'I feel ___ when ___ because ___' instead of blaming 'you' statements.

Why it works. Non-blaming communication reduces defensiveness and assigns feelings to the self rather than attacking the other

3-step guide

1. Identify your feeling and the specific behavior (not the person) that triggered it.
2. Frame it: 'I feel [emotion] when [specific behavior] because [impact on you],' avoiding 'you always/you never.'
3. Make a clear request: 'I'd appreciate it if [specific, doable change]'

Best for: Conflict, Intense Anger, Work Pressure

Time to impact: 1-3 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip Replaces blame with clarity — keeps the other person able to hear you. —

I08 — Repair Attempt

Interpersonal Effectiveness · Advanced · ~5-10 min · Anywhere

What it is. Reach out after a conflict to acknowledge your part, validate the impact, and recommit — repairing the rupture.

Why it works. Relationship repair — acknowledging impact and taking accountability rebuilds trust after a rupture

3-step guide

1. Name what you did and its impact without minimizing or over-apologizing: 'I raised my voice, and that was unfair to you.'
2. Validate their experience: 'I understand why that felt dismissive.'
3. State what you'll do differently and recommit to the relationship — repair is about behavior change, not just words.

Best for: Conflict, Shame, Loneliness

Time to impact: 5-15 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Advanced

[!tip] Tip Effective only when sincere and followed by changed behavior. —

109 — Time-Out Request

Interpersonal Effectiveness · Beginner · ~Under 1 min · Anywhere

What it is. Call a brief, structured break when a conversation is heating past your ability to stay skillful — and commit to returning.

Why it works. De-escalation — a planned pause prevents flooding-driven conflict escalation and protects the relationship from regrettable words

3-step guide

1. Notice the physical signs you're flooding (heat, racing heart, urge to win or hurt) before you act on them.
2. Say: 'I need 20 minutes to calm down; I want to finish this well, so let's take a break and come back.'
3. Use the break to regulate (breathing, walk), then return as promised — the return is what builds trust.

Best for: Intense Anger, Conflict, Overwhelm

Time to impact: 30 seconds to request · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Beginner

[!tip] Tip Always state when you'll return; a break with no return is abandonment, not a time-out. —

110 — Clarify Assumptions

Interpersonal Effectiveness · Intermediate · ~2–5 min · Anywhere

What it is. Before reacting to what you think someone meant, check the assumption by asking, not by mind-reading.

Why it works. Reality-testing reduces the suffering caused by unverified assumptions about others' thoughts and motives

3-step guide

1. Notice the story you're telling yourself about their intent ('She's ignoring me on purpose').
2. List two alternative explanations for their behavior that don't require malice (busy, distracted, unaware).
3. If it matters, ask directly and curiously: 'I noticed ____ — can you help me understand?' instead of accusing.

Best for: Social Anxiety, Conflict, Rumination
Time to impact: 3-5 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Intermediate

[!tip] Tip Cuts the chain of rumination and imagined slights at its root. —

I11 — Walking the Middle Path

Interpersonal Effectiveness · Advanced · ~2-5 min · Anywhere

What it is. Look for the middle path between two opposing positions, recognizing that two things that seem contradictory can both be true.

Why it works. Dialectical thinking — moving past all-or-nothing, either/or positions to a synthesis that holds two truths at once

3-step guide

1. Notice the either/or framing (‘I’m right, they’re wrong’ / ‘it’s all my fault or all theirs’).
2. Ask: ‘What’s true in both positions? Where can both be partly right?’
3. Move toward a synthesis that honors both truths rather than forcing a winner.

Best for: Conflict, Shame, Social Anxiety
Time to impact: 3-5 minutes · **Setting:** Anywhere · **Level:** Advanced

[!tip] Tip ‘Both/and’ thinking beats ‘either/or’ in nearly every conflict. —

Index by difficulty

Beginner

ID	Skill	Module	Time	Setting
M01	Wise Mind Check-In	Mindfulness	Under 1 min	Anywhere
M03	One-Mindfully	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Anywhere
M05	5-4-3-2-1 Grounding	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Anywhere
M06	Breath Counting	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Anywhere
D01	STOP Skill	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Anywhere

ID	Skill	Module	Time	Setting
D02	TIPP — Temperature	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Private
D03	Paced Breathing	Distress Tolerance	2-5 min	Anywhere
D05	ACCEPTS Distraction	Distress Tolerance	5-10 min	Anywhere
E04	PLEASE Skills	Emotion Regulation	15+ min	Anywhere
E07	Name the Emotion	Emotion Regulation	1-2 min	Anywhere
I05	Broken Record	Interpersonal Effectiveness	1-2 min	Anywhere
I07	Assertive I-Statements	Interpersonal Effectiveness	1-2 min	Anywhere
I09	Time-Out Request	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Under 1 min	Anywhere
M13	Savoring	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Anywhere
M14	Gratitude Journaling	Mindfulness	5-10 min	Anywhere
D13	Half-Smile & Willing Hands	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Anywhere
E12	Build Mastery	Emotion Regulation	15+ min	Anywhere

Intermediate

ID	Skill	Module	Time	Setting
M02	Observe-Describe-Participate	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Anywhere
M04	Nonjudgmental Stance	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Anywhere
M07	Body Scan	Mindfulness	5-10 min	Private
M08	Thought Labeling	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Anywhere
D04	Paired Muscle Relaxation	Distress Tolerance	5-10 min	Private
D06	Self-Soothe (Five Senses)	Distress Tolerance	5-10 min	Private

ID	Skill	Module	Time	Setting
D07	IMPROVE the Moment	Distress Tolerance	5-10 min	Private
D08	Pros and Cons	Distress Tolerance	2-5 min	Anywhere
E01	Check the Facts	Emotion Regulation	5-10 min	Anywhere
E02	Opposite Action	Emotion Regulation	5-10 min	Anywhere
E03	Problem Solving	Emotion Regulation	10-15 min	Private
E05	Build Positive Experiences	Emotion Regulation	15+ min	Anywhere
E06	Cope Ahead	Emotion Regulation	5-10 min	Private
I01	DEAR MAN	Interpersonal Effectiveness	5-10 min	Anywhere
I02	GIVE	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Anywhere
I03	FAST	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Anywhere
I04	Boundary Script	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Anywhere
I06	Validation Before Request	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Anywhere
I10	Clarify Assumptions	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Anywhere
M11	Effectiveness (Do What Works)	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Anywhere
M12	Loving-Kindness (Metta) Practice	Mindfulness	5-10 min	Private
M15	Self-Compassion Break	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Anywhere
D11	Turning the Mind	Distress Tolerance	1-2 min	Anywhere
D12	Willingness vs. Willfulness	Distress Tolerance	1-2 min	Anywhere
D14	Mindfulness of Current Thoughts	Distress Tolerance	5-10 min	Private

ID	Skill	Module	Time	Setting
E11	Mindfulness of Current Emotion	Emotion Regulation	5-10 min	Anywhere
E13	Accumulate Positive Emotions (Long-Term)	Emotion Regulation	15+ min	Anywhere
E15	Identifying Cognitive Distortions	Emotion Regulation	2-5 min	Anywhere
E17	Worry Postponement	Emotion Regulation	1-2 min	Anywhere
E18	Activity Scheduling (Behavioral Activation)	Emotion Regulation	10-15 min	Anywhere

Advanced

ID	Skill	Module	Time	Setting
M09	Leaves on a Stream	Mindfulness	5-10 min	Private
M10	Urge Surfing	Mindfulness	5-10 min	Anywhere
D09	Radical Acceptance	Distress Tolerance	5-10 min	Anywhere
D10	Crisis Survival Plan	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Anywhere
E08	Emotion Wave Mapping	Emotion Regulation	5-10 min	Private
E09	Cognitive Reframing	Emotion Regulation	5-10 min	Anywhere
E10	Values-Based Action	Emotion Regulation	5-10 min	Anywhere
I08	Repair Attempt	Interpersonal Effectiveness	5-10 min	Anywhere
E14	Thought Record (CBT)	Emotion Regulation	5-10 min	Anywhere
E16	Behavioral Experiments (CBT)	Emotion Regulation	15+ min	Anywhere
I11	Walking the Middle Path	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Anywhere

Index by situation & emotion

For each common stressor, the skills most likely to help — ranked by speed and fit.

Panic

Skill	Module	Time	Level
TIPP — Temperature	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Beginner
Half-Smile & Willing Hands	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Beginner
5-4-3-2-1 Grounding	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Beginner
Breath Counting	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Beginner
Observe-Describe-Participate	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Intermediate
Crisis Survival Plan	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Advanced

Social Anxiety

Skill	Module	Time	Level
Broken Record	Interpersonal Effectiveness	1-2 min	Beginner
Validation Before Request	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Intermediate
Clarify Assumptions	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Intermediate
GIVE	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Intermediate
FAST	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Intermediate
Walking the Middle Path	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Advanced

Work Pressure

Skill	Module	Time	Level
One-Mindfully	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Beginner
Breath Counting	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Beginner

Skill	Module	Time	Level
Assertive I-Statements	Interpersonal Effectiveness	1-2 min	Beginner
Effectiveness (Do What Works)	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Intermediate
Worry Postponement	Emotion Regulation	1-2 min	Intermediate
Paced Breathing	Distress Tolerance	2-5 min	Beginner

Intense Anger

Skill	Module	Time	Level
STOP Skill	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Beginner
Time-Out Request	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Under 1 min	Beginner
TIPP — Temperature	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Beginner
Half-Smile & Willing Hands	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Beginner
Broken Record	Interpersonal Effectiveness	1-2 min	Beginner
Assertive I-Statements	Interpersonal Effectiveness	1-2 min	Beginner

Shame

Skill	Module	Time	Level
Name the Emotion	Emotion Regulation	1-2 min	Beginner
Nonjudgmental Stance	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Intermediate
Thought Labeling	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Intermediate
Self-Compassion Break	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Intermediate
Identifying Cognitive Distortions	Emotion Regulation	2-5 min	Intermediate
FAST	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Intermediate

Sadness

Skill	Module	Time	Level
Turning the Mind	Distress Tolerance	1-2 min	Intermediate
Savoring	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Beginner
Self-Compassion Break	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Intermediate
Gratitude Journaling	Mindfulness	5-10 min	Beginner
ACCEPTS Distraction	Distress Tolerance	5-10 min	Beginner
Build Mastery	Emotion Regulation	15+ min	Beginner

Rumination

Skill	Module	Time	Level
Wise Mind Check-In	Mindfulness	Under 1 min	Beginner
One-Mindfully	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Beginner
Name the Emotion	Emotion Regulation	1-2 min	Beginner
Observe-Describe-Participate	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Intermediate
Worry Postponement	Emotion Regulation	1-2 min	Intermediate
Savoring	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Beginner

Conflict

Skill	Module	Time	Level
Wise Mind Check-In	Mindfulness	Under 1 min	Beginner
STOP Skill	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Beginner
Time-Out Request	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Under 1 min	Beginner
Broken Record	Interpersonal Effectiveness	1-2 min	Beginner
Assertive I-Statements	Interpersonal Effectiveness	1-2 min	Beginner
Effectiveness (Do What Works)	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Intermediate

Urges & Cravings

Skill	Module	Time	Level
STOP Skill	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Beginner
Crisis Survival Plan	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Advanced
Pros and Cons	Distress Tolerance	2-5 min	Intermediate
ACCEPTS Distraction	Distress Tolerance	5-10 min	Beginner
Urge Surfing	Mindfulness	5-10 min	Advanced

Overwhelm

Skill	Module	Time	Level
Wise Mind Check-In	Mindfulness	Under 1 min	Beginner
Time-Out Request	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Under 1 min	Beginner
TIPP — Temperature	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Beginner
5-4-3-2-1 Grounding	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Beginner
One-Mindfully	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Beginner
Breath Counting	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Beginner

Grief

Skill	Module	Time	Level
Half-Smile & Willing Hands	Distress Tolerance	Under 1 min	Beginner
Turning the Mind	Distress Tolerance	1-2 min	Intermediate
Willingness vs. Willfulness	Distress Tolerance	1-2 min	Intermediate
Self-Compassion Break	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Intermediate
IMPROVE the Moment	Distress Tolerance	5-10 min	Intermediate
Leaves on a Stream	Mindfulness	5-10 min	Advanced

Loneliness

Skill	Module	Time	Level
Savoring	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Beginner

Skill	Module	Time	Level
Validation Before Request	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Intermediate
GIVE	Interpersonal Effectiveness	2-5 min	Intermediate
Gratitude Journaling	Mindfulness	5-10 min	Beginner
Build Mastery	Emotion Regulation	15+ min	Beginner
Self-Soothe (Five Senses)	Distress Tolerance	5-10 min	Intermediate

Dissociation

Skill	Module	Time	Level
5-4-3-2-1 Grounding	Mindfulness	1-2 min	Beginner

Self-Criticism

Skill	Module	Time	Level
Nonjudgmental Stance	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Intermediate
Self-Compassion Break	Mindfulness	2-5 min	Intermediate
Identifying Cognitive Distortions	Emotion Regulation	2-5 min	Intermediate
Loving-Kindness (Metta) Practice	Mindfulness	5-10 min	Intermediate

Master reference table

All 58 skills at a glance, sorted by module. Use search (Ctrl/⌘ + F) to find any skill, mechanism, or stressor instantly.

ID	Skill	Module	Level	Time	Setting	Primary mechanism
M01	Wise Mind Check-In	Mindfulness	Beg	Under 1 min	Anywhere	Cognitive integration — merging emotional and logical processing into integrated,

ID	Skill	Module	Level	Time	Setting	Primary mechanism
						values-aligned judgment
M02	Observe-Describe-Participate	Mindfulness	Int	1–2 min	Anywhere	Defusion and attentional control — naming experience creates distance from it and disrupts automatic reactivity
M03	One-Mindfully	Mindfulness	Beg	1–2 min	Anywhere	Attentional narrowing and single-tasking reduce cognitive load and lower sympathetic arousal
M04	Nonjudgmental Stance	Mindfulness	Int	2–5 min	Anywhere	Cognitive defusion — dropping evaluative labels reduces the secondary suffering layered on top of the original emotion
M05	5-4-3-2-1 Grounding	Mindfulness	Beg	1–2 min	Anywhere	Sensory grounding redirects attention from internal threat signals to the present external environment, interrupting panic loops
M06	Breath Counting	Mindfulness	Beg	1–2 min	Anywhere	Paced diaphragmatic breathing activates the parasympathetic nervous system

ID	Skill	Module	Level	Time	Setting	Primary mechanism
						and slows heart rate
M07	Body Scan	Mindfulness	Int	5–10 min	Private	Interoceptive awareness releases held muscle tension and reconnects mind to body, lowering overall arousal
M08	Thought Labeling	Mindfulness	Int	2–5 min	Anywhere	Cognitive defusion — prefacing thoughts with ‘I’m having the thought that...’ reduces literal belief in the thought’s content
M09	Leaves on a Stream	Mindfulness	Adv	5–10 min	Private	Acceptance-based defusion — placing thoughts on a visualized stream trains the mind to let experiences pass without attachment
M10	Urge Surfing	Mindfulness	Adv	5–10 min	Anywhere	Distress tolerance through mindful observation — urges crest and fall like waves if not acted on, typically peaking within 20-30 minutes
D01	STOP Skill	Distress Tolerance	Beg	Under 1 min	Anywhere	Response inhibition — a behavioral circuit-breaker that inserts a pause between impulse and action

ID	Skill	Module	Level	Time	Setting	Primary mechanism
D02	TIPP — Temperature	Distress Tolerance	Beg	Under 1 min	Private	Mammalian dive reflex — cold water on the face triggers the vagus nerve, rapidly slowing heart rate and interrupting extreme emotional arousal
D03	Paced Breathing	Distress Tolerance	Beg	2–5 min	Anywhere	Extending the exhale activates the parasympathetic nervous system, lowering heart rate and cortisol
D04	Paired Muscle Relaxation	Distress Tolerance	Int	5–10 min	Private	Progressive muscle relaxation lowers sympathetic tone and teaches the body the contrast between tension and release
D05	ACCEPTS Distraction	Distress Tolerance	Beg	5–10 min	Anywhere	Attentional deployment — engaging alternative stimuli gives the emotional system time to settle without suppressing the feeling
D06	Self-Soothe (Five Senses)	Distress Tolerance	Int	5–10 min	Private	Sensory regulation and self-care — soothing input to each sense lowers arousal and signals safety to the nervous system

ID	Skill	Module	Level	Time	Setting	Primary mechanism
D07	IMPROVE the Moment	Distress Tolerance	Int	5–10 min	Private	Meaning-making and cognitive reappraisal transform an unchangeable painful moment into one that is bearable
D08	Pros and Cons	Distress Tolerance	Int	2–5 min	Anywhere	Deliberate cost-benefit analysis engages prefrontal cortex, countering emotion-driven impulsivity
D09	Radical Acceptance	Distress Tolerance	Adv	5–10 min	Anywhere	Acceptance reduces secondary suffering — fighting unchangeable reality amplifies pain, while accepting it frees energy for coping
D10	Crisis Survival Plan	Distress Tolerance	Adv	Under 1 min	Anywhere	Implementation intention — pre-deciding coping steps in a calm state bypasses the impaired decision-making of a crisis
E01	Check the Facts	Emotion Regulation	Int	5–10 min	Anywhere	Cognitive restructuring — testing whether an emotion's intensity fits the facts and examining interpretations that drive it
E02	Opposite Action	Emotion Regulation	Int	5–10 min	Anywhere	Behavioral activation —

ID	Skill	Module	Level	Time	Setting	Primary mechanism
						acting opposite to an emotion's action urge (when the emotion doesn't fit the facts) weakens the emotion
E03	Problem Solving	Emotion Regulation	Int	10-15 min	Private	Structured problem-solving reduces helplessness and converts emotional energy into controllable next steps
E04	PLEASE Skills	Emotion Regulation	Beg	15+ min	Anywhere	Reducing biological vulnerability — treating physical illness, balanced eating, avoiding mood-altering substances, sleep, exercise lowers emotional reactivity
E05	Build Positive Experiences	Emotion Regulation	Int	15+ min	Anywhere	Behavioral activation and reward — scheduling pleasant and mastery-building activities raises mood floor and counters anhedonia
E06	Cope Ahead	Emotion Regulation	Int	5-10 min	Private	Mental rehearsal and implementation intentions — pre-rehearsing a coping plan reduces anxiety and increases

ID	Skill	Module	Level	Time	Setting	Primary mechanism
						follow-through in the real moment
E07	Name the Emotion	Emotion Regulation	Beg	1–2 min	Anywhere	Affect labeling — putting words to feelings reduces amygdala activity and engages prefrontal regulation
E08	Emotion Wave Mapping	Emotion Regulation	Adv	5–10 min	Private	Psychoeducation and temporal reframing — visualizing emotions as time-limited waves reduces fear of the feeling itself
E09	Cognitive Reframing	Emotion Regulation	Adv	5–10 min	Anywhere	Cognitive restructuring (CBT) — identifying and re-evaluating distorted automatic thoughts to change the emotions they generate
E10	Values-Based Action	Emotion Regulation	Adv	5–10 min	Anywhere	Values clarification (ACT) — connecting behavior to core values provides meaning and direction independent of current mood
I01	DEAR MAN	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Int	5–10 min	Anywhere	Assertiveness training — a structured script for making requests or saying no while protecting the

ID	Skill	Module	Level	Time	Setting	Primary mechanism
						relationship and self-respect
I02	GIVE	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Int	2–5 min	Anywhere	Relationship preservation — acting Gentle, Interested, Validating, and with an Easy manner keeps the other person receptive
I03	FAST	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Int	2–5 min	Anywhere	Self-respect preservation — staying Fair, making no Apologies for existing, Sticking to values, and being Truthful protects self-worth
I04	Boundary Script	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Int	2–5 min	Anywhere	Assertive limit-setting reduces resentment and burnout by making your limits explicit and respectful
I05	Broken Record	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Beg	1–2 min	Anywhere	Persistence without escalation — repeating a clear statement avoids being drawn into argument or emotional derailment
I06	Validation Before Request	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Int	2–5 min	Anywhere	Reflective listening lowers the other's defensiveness, making them far more receptive to your needs

ID	Skill	Module	Level	Time	Setting	Primary mechanism
I07	Assertive I-Statements	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Beg	1–2 min	Anywhere	Non-blaming communication reduces defensiveness and assigns feelings to the self rather than attacking the other
I08	Repair Attempt	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Adv	5–10 min	Anywhere	Relationship repair — acknowledging impact and taking accountability rebuilds trust after a rupture
I09	Time-Out Request	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Beg	Under 1 min	Anywhere	De-escalation — a planned pause prevents flooding-driven conflict escalation and protects the relationship from regrettable words
I10	Clarify Assumptions	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Int	2–5 min	Anywhere	Reality-testing reduces the suffering caused by unverified assumptions about others' thoughts and motives
M11	Effectiveness (Do What Works)	Mindfulness	Int	1–2 min	Anywhere	Pragmatic problem-solving — focusing on what is effective rather than what is morally 'right' reduces rigid, emotion-driven reactivity
M12	Loving-Kindness	Mindfulness	Int	5–10 min	Private	Compassion-focused imagery activates the

ID	Skill	Module	Level	Time	Setting	Primary mechanism
	(Metta) Practice					mammalian affiliative/soothing system, countering self-criticism and social-threat responses
M13	Savoring	Mindfulness	Beg	2–5 min	Anywhere	Deliberately prolonging attention on positive experiences counteracts the negativity bias and builds positive affect
M14	Gratitude Journaling	Mindfulness	Beg	5–10 min	Anywhere	Intentional gratitude practice retrains attention toward positive aspects of life, reducing depressive rumination and raising baseline mood
M15	Self-Compassion Break	Mindfulness	Int	2–5 min	Anywhere	Self-compassion (Kristin Neff’s three components) activates the soothing/affiliative system, reducing shame-based self-attack and isolation
D11	Turning the Mind	Distress Tolerance	Int	1–2 min	Anywhere	Repeatedly choosing acceptance — turning the mind back toward reality each time it resists — builds the capacity to

ID	Skill	Module	Level	Time	Setting	Primary mechanism
						stop fighting the unchangeable
D12	Willingness vs. Willfulness	Distress Tolerance	Int	1–2 min	Anywhere	Shifting from willful refusal to willing participation reduces the suffering that comes from fighting what the situation requires
D13	Half-Smile & Willing Hands	Distress Tolerance	Beg	Under 1 min	Anywhere	Adopting an accepting body posture (slight smile, open palms) sends acceptance signals to the nervous system, reducing the resistance that amplifies distress
D14	Mindfulness of Current Thoughts	Distress Tolerance	Int	5–10 min	Private	Defusion — observing thoughts as passing mental events rather than truths reduces literal belief in their content and the distress they generate
E11	Mindfulness of Current Emotion	Emotion Regulation	Int	5–10 min	Anywhere	Observing an emotion fully — without pushing it away or acting on it — reduces its intensity and the secondary suffering of resistance
E12	Build Mastery	Emotion Regulation	Beg	15+ min	Anywhere	Accomplishing tasks builds self-

ID	Skill	Module	Level	Time	Setting	Primary mechanism
						efficacy and raises the mood floor, countering helplessness and low mood
E13	Accumulate Positive Emotions (Long-Term)	Emotion Regulation	Int	15+ min	Anywhere	Building a life with positive experiences and meaning raises the long-term mood floor and buffers against future emotional crashes
E14	Thought Record (CBT)	Emotion Regulation	Adv	5–10 min	Anywhere	The CBT thought record externalizes automatic thoughts, tests them against evidence, and builds balanced alternatives — restructuring the cognition driving the emotion
E15	Identifying Cognitive Distortions	Emotion Regulation	Int	2–5 min	Anywhere	Naming the specific distortion (catastrophizing, all-or-nothing, mind-reading) weakens its grip by making the thinking error visible
E16	Behavioral Experiments (CBT)	Emotion Regulation	Adv	15+ min	Anywhere	CBT behavioral experiments directly test the predictions of anxious beliefs against reality, providing experiential disconfirmation

ID	Skill	Module	Level	Time	Setting	Primary mechanism
						that cognitive argument cannot
E17	Worry Postponement	Emotion Regulation	Int	1–2 min	Anywhere	Scheduling a fixed ‘worry time’ contains rumination rather than suppressing it, reducing intrusion outside the window
E18	Activity Scheduling (Behavioral Activation)	Emotion Regulation	Int	10–15 min	Anywhere	Behavioral activation — scheduling mastery and pleasure activities into the day — breaks the depression-inactivity cycle where low mood leads to withdrawal and deeper low mood
I11	Walking the Middle Path	Interpersonal Effectiveness	Adv	2–5 min	Anywhere	Dialectical thinking — moving past all-or-nothing, either/or positions to a synthesis that holds two truths at once

Wisdom Literature Cross-Reference

The book of Psalms and the book of Proverbs function as early repositories of psychological observation, emotional processing, and lifestyle design. The 40 skills below translate their insights into modern clinical concepts that closely parallel the CBT and DBT skills in this guide. Each entry lists the skill, the psychological mechanism behind it, and the wisdom-text reference it is drawn from.

[!info] About the references References are to the books of Psalms (Ps) and Proverbs (Prov) in the Hebrew Bible / Old Testament. These are literary and historical references, not medical

guidance.

#	Skill	Psychological mechanism	Wisdom reference
1	Authentic emotional ventilation (affect labeling)	Giving verbal form to intense distress instead of repressing it reduces amygdala activation and internal emotional pressure.	Psalms 13:1-2; Psalm 62:8
2	Somatic grounding and stillness (Selah pause)	Taking deliberate, rhythmic pauses in acute stress resets parasympathetic nervous system tone.	Psalms 46:10
3	De-escalating reactive anger	Choosing a measured tone during volatile moments lowers emotional temperature and prevents mutual escalation.	Proverbs 15:1
4	Delayed response and impulse control	Inserting a conscious gap between an emotional trigger and physical action prevents impulsive behavior.	Proverbs 14:29; Proverbs 29:11
5	Holding situational impermanence	Viewing crises as temporary chapters rather than permanent realities reduces hopelessness.	Psalms 30:5
6	Radical acceptance of limits	Relinquishing futile attempts to control uncontrollable variables and accepting baseline reality without resistance.	Psalms 131:1-2; Proverbs 3:5-6
7	Somatic discharge of grief	Allowing natural physiological responses like crying to release held emotional tension.	Psalms 6:6; Psalm 56:8
8	Cognitive containment of rage	Setting healthy time boundaries on anger to	Proverbs 19:11; Proverbs 27:3

#	Skill	Psychological mechanism	Wisdom reference
		prevent it solidifying into chronic bitterness.	
9	Challenging negative automatic thoughts	Confronting catastrophic or depressive internal narratives by interrogating unhelpful assumptions.	Psalms 42:5; Psalm 42:11
10	Attentional deployment and meditation	Anchoring attention onto constructive, calming concepts rather than ruminative thoughts.	Psalms 1:2; Psalm 19:14
11	Information filtering (guarding inputs)	Actively curating internal and external mental stimuli to protect emotional equilibrium.	Proverbs 4:23
12	Gratitude-based perspective shifting	Re-centering cognitive bias toward resilience by deliberately recounting positive markers.	Psalms 103:1-5
13	Decatastrophizing future uncertainty	Breaking future-oriented anxiety loops by restricting cognitive bandwidth to the present day.	Psalms 118:24; Proverbs 27:1
14	Mind-body psychosomatic awareness	Acknowledging how chronic negative emotional states directly degrade physical health.	Proverbs 14:30; Proverbs 17:22
15	Countering toxic comparison	Mitigating self-generated inadequacy by focusing on personal growth rather than peer status.	Psalms 73:2-3; Proverbs 14:30
16	Cognitive reframing of adversity	Reinterpreting pain and setbacks as developmental tools	Psalms 119:71; Proverbs 3:11-12

#	Skill	Psychological mechanism	Wisdom reference
		that build endurance and maturity.	
17	Toxicity triage and boundary setting	Creating firm physical and relational distance from hostile or dysregulated personalities.	Proverbs 22:24-25
18	Collaborative consultation	Actively seeking multiperspective counsel to eliminate personal blind spots in complex decisions.	Proverbs 11:14; Proverbs 15:22
19	Strategic silence	Recognizing when speech offers diminishing returns and withholding responses to preserve relational stability.	Proverbs 17:28
20	Verbal validation and affirmation	Using deliberate, uplifting language to soothe anxiety and restore another person's emotional state.	Proverbs 12:25
21	Conflict de-escalation by avoiding gossip	Eliminating indirect communication and hearsay to starve interpersonal conflict of fuel.	Proverbs 26:20
22	Constructive confrontation	Delivering clear, timely feedback directly to address boundary violations before resentment deepens.	Proverbs 27:5-6
23	Prudent self-disclosure	Exercising discernment regarding how much private detail to share and with whom.	Proverbs 10:19; Proverbs 29:11
24	Empathetic solidarity	Mirroring another person's emotional state with genuine	Psalms 35:13-14; Proverbs 25:20

#	Skill	Psychological mechanism	Wisdom reference
		presence rather than invalidating platitudes.	
25	Incremental skill accumulation	Emphasizing small, steady gains over unsustainable shortcuts to build lasting progress.	Proverbs 13:11
26	Anti-procrastination initiation	Overcoming behavioral avoidance through immediate, self-directed small steps.	Proverbs 6:6-8; Proverbs 20:13
27	Sleep hygiene and evening detachment	Intentionally disconnecting from daytime anxiety to ensure restorative physical and cognitive rest.	Psalms 3:5; Psalm 4:8; Proverbs 3:24
28	Financial stress mitigation	Moderating lifestyle desires to stay within existing resources, curbing chronic economic anxiety.	Proverbs 21:20
29	Values-aligned decision frameworks	Developing a pre-committed ethical baseline that guides quick, low-regret behavioral choices.	Proverbs 11:3; Proverbs 16:3
30	Active environmental pacing	Avoiding dangerous triggers and high-risk environments before temptation or impulsive urges arise.	Proverbs 4:14-15; Proverbs 22:3
31	Routine scheduling and stewardship	Structuring day-to-day duties systematically to decrease chaos and executive dysfunction.	Proverbs 24:27; Proverbs 27:23-24
32	Altruistic activation	Actively supporting vulnerable individuals to disrupt self-absorbed rumination cycles.	Psalms 82:3-4; Proverbs 31:8-9

#	Skill	Psychological mechanism	Wisdom reference
33	Non-defensive receptivity to criticism	Viewing critical feedback as valuable data rather than an existential threat to the ego.	Proverbs 12:1; Proverbs 15:31-32
34	Psychological self-auditing	Regularly reviewing unconscious motivations, personal biases, and behavioral patterns.	Psalm 139:23-24; Proverbs 20:27
35	Humor and positive affect integration	Using laughter and positive experiences as active, restorative interventions for stamina.	Proverbs 17:22
36	Cultivating humility against grandiosity	Grounding self-perception in realistic terms to prevent depressive crashes following ego inflation.	Proverbs 16:18; Proverbs 18:12
37	Reparation after interpersonal harm	Taking immediate behavioral responsibility and offering restitution when one's actions cause damage.	Psalm 51:1-4; Proverbs 28:13
38	Savoring natural environments	Resetting neurological overstimulation through deliberate exposure to the natural world.	Psalm 19:1-4; Psalm 104:14-24
39	Acceptance of existential vulnerability	Embracing human limitations and short lifespans to cultivate daily intentionality and focus.	Psalm 90:12
40	Long-term perspective over instant gratification	Valuing patient character growth over immediate sensory or emotional payoff.	Proverbs 14:12; Proverbs 20:21

Sources & further reading

1. Linehan Institute — DBT Skills Training Manual — linehaninstitute.org
 2. U.S. Dept. of Veterans Affairs MIRECC — DBT: A Visual Review — mirecc.va.gov
 3. U.S. HHS Administration for Children & Families — DBT evidence review — preventionservices.acf.hhs.gov
 4. National Center for Biotechnology Information — DBT modules overview — pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov
 5. West Virginia University School of Medicine — Skills taught in DBT — medicine.hsc.wvu.edu
 6. 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline — 988lifeline.org
-

This reference guide was compiled as an educational overview of widely taught DBT and CBT coping skills. Skill names and module groupings follow the standard DBT skills structure. Always consult a qualified mental-health professional for personal care.